HERITAGE

LIVING HERITAGE

Kathika, a new museum and cultural hub occupying two restored havelis in Old Delhi, is a great example of adaptive reuse of heritage buildings

Nestled within Old Delhi's Sitaram Bazaar, a hop, skip and jump away from Gali Khatikan's serene-looking Hanuman Mandir, lies the Kathika Cultural Centre, a new non-profit 'haveli-museum' that seeks to become the city's latest cultural hub. As the name suggests, 'Kathika' (which began operations in May) is inspired by storytelling traditions like *kathawachan* and *dastangoi*. Comprising two havelis that face each other, the space is choc-a-bloc with all manner of fascinating, nostalgia-provoking artefacts, books, photographs, statuettes, knick-knacks from previous decades, portions of 'legacy tech' machines (old typewriters, vintage scooters) and much else. There is an indoor, air-conditioned seating space and a lovely, old-fashioned courtyard. One of the havelis (fittingly, called Neem Ki Haveli), is constructed all around a majestic neem tree (I'm no expert, but that tree has surely witnessed over a hundred summers) that lends an agreeably old-school aura to the surroundings.

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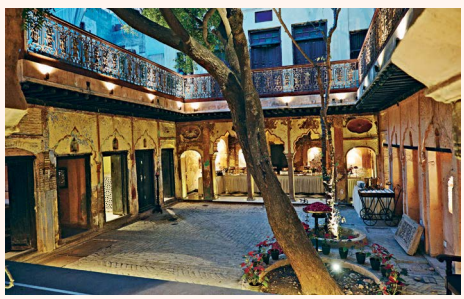
So far, the indoor space has been used for cultural events—the poet-diplomat Abhay K. recently launched his new book of poems, *Monsoon*, here. In July, the artist Amrai Dua organised an art workshop on the 116th birth anniversary of the iconic painter Frida Kahlo. Since then, there have been other events as well; historian Sohail Hashmi recently spoke about the cultural, historic and, of course, gastronomic significance of the mango. Recently, Kathika celebrated World Photography Day (August 19) by organising an Old Delhi walk followed by some live western music on the premises. Both havelis are undergoing the final, cosmetic stages of renovation and soon, the Kathika Cultural Centre will be ready to mount its own themed exhibits, complete with screening rooms for audio-visual presentations.

One of the great things about the artefacts here is that there is barely any distinction between conventionally understood 'high culture' and more proletarian or commercial expressions. For example, a small, cute figurine of a 'Murphy baby' from the popular, eponymous 1970s advertisements, will greet you very close to an array of Raja Ravi Varmas and Madhubani paintings. An iconic black-and-white photograph of Jawaharlal Nehru with the Mountbattens shares space with a splashy, flamboyant advertisement featuring 'The Great Gama' (Ghulam Mohammad Baksh, a legendary, undefeated wrestler from early 20th century British India).

Kathika's founder, Atul Khanna, whose family home is in Chandni Chowk, has been involved in restoration projects in the past as well. Over a decade ago, Khanna purchased and restored an old haveli in Mandawa, Rajasthan; it now functions as the Vivaana Culture Hotel. With Kathika, the immediate objective may be different—creating a cultural hub as opposed to a hotel—but the passion for history is the same. And it's palpable when you walk around Kathika. ■

Aditya Mani Jha







Photographs by SUNDEEP BALI, *courtesy:* KATHIKA

Kathika Cultural Centre, 1237, Gali Khatikan, Imli Mohalla, Kucha Pati Ram, Sitaram Bazar, Delhi 110006; Open daily from 10 am to 6.30 pm